

The Picture Wall (Deewar-e-Jahangiri)

دیوار جهانگیری

1. Basic Facts

- Built by: Commissioned by Emperor Jahangir, completed under Emperor Shah Jahan
- Built in: Begun around 1624-25, completed around 1631-32
- Cost: Not documented in available sources
- Built for: A monumental decorated outer facade celebrating Mughal power, forming the fort's western, northern and northeastern street-facing wall

2. Construction Details

- Materials and techniques: Glazed tile mosaic (kashi-kari), fresco/lime-plaster painting (naqqashi), brick-imitation work (taza-kari), stalactite/muqarnas plaster work (qalib-kari), cut-and-dressed brickwork, marble and red-sandstone lattice (jali) screens, and terracotta relief
- Scale: Sources differ - roughly 450 metres long by 17 metres high in older estimates, versus a more recent AKTC-sourced figure of about 480 metres long by an average 21 metres high; commonly described as one of the largest pictorial wall-mosaics in the world
- Panel count: Roughly 2,000 richly ornamented recessed panels across three tiers (an older estimate cites over 3,000 individual glazed tile/fresco panels)
- Craftsmen involved: Not individually documented for the original 17th-century construction

3. Historical Background

- Subject matter includes hunting and battle scenes, royal processions, angels and demons, human figures, animals and birds, alongside geometric and floral motifs - a synthesis of Persian, Central Asian and South Asian artistic traditions, and in places explicit court propaganda celebrating Mughal power and pageantry.
- Multiple sources, including UNESCO's own 2026 statement, identify the Picture Wall's craftsmanship as one of the principal reasons Lahore Fort was inscribed on the World Heritage List in 1981.
- For the specific causes of the wall's deterioration, see the separate "Damage and Causes" entry; for the full 2015-2026 conservation project, see the separate "Restoration Project" entry.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- During 2023 conservation work on the wall, workers uncovered original Mughal-era terracotta water pipes that were reportedly still capable of holding water after roughly 390 years.
- The wall runs alongside the Shah Burj Gate (Hathi Pol), meaning even the fort's private royal entrance was flanked by some of its most elaborate public artwork.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

Stand where a Mughal courtier once stood in 1632, looking up at two thousand small glazed windows into another world - elephants charging, angels hovering, emperors riding in procession, all baked into tile that was never meant to fade.

AI Heritage Revive — Lahore Fort landmark reference. Compiled from encyclopedic research report; figures marked "Not documented" are intentionally left blank rather than estimated.